How to Write a PhD Dissertation

From Proposal to Defence

A Thesis Guide

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Abstract

A doctoral dissertation is the longest and most demanding piece of writing most students will ever produce. It is not simply a longer master's thesis: it must make an original contribution to knowledge, sustain a single argument over tens of thousands of words, and survive an oral examination by experts in the field. This guide follows the whole journey, from the first research proposal to the defence and the final submission, and explains what changes at each stage, what examiners look for, and which habits keep a long project moving.

The guide begins by explaining how doctoral work differs from master's work, and how to plan a realistic multi-year timeline with clear milestones. It then covers the proposal, the originality requirement, the doctoral literature review, methodology and research design, fieldwork and data collection, analysis and results, and the discussion chapter in which the contribution is claimed. Later chapters deal with the practical side of the doctorate: building a sustainable drafting routine, working with a supervisor and a committee, preparing for the defence (viva), making corrections, and submitting the final thesis.

Throughout, the emphasis is practical rather than theoretical. Each chapter includes worked examples, sample tables, and checklists that a candidate can use before sending a draft to a supervisor or before the defence itself. The advice applies to doctoral study in the social sciences, humanities, education, business and the applied sciences, and it can be adapted to the regulations of any university.

Keywords: PhD dissertation, doctoral thesis, research proposal, originality, literature review, methodology, viva, defence, supervisor.

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How to use this guide: read Chapters 1 and 2 before you apply or begin, to understand the scale of the doctorate and to plan your timeline. Read Chapters 3 to 6 as you prepare your proposal and design your study. Use Chapters 7 to 9 while you collect and analyse data, Chapters 10 and 11 throughout the writing years, and Chapters 12 to 14 in the final months before and after your defence.

Chapter 1: PhD vs Master's — What Changes

Students who finished a master's thesis often assume that a PhD is the same task, only longer. That assumption causes more trouble than any other in the first year of a doctorate. A master's thesis demonstrates that you can carry out a piece of research competently and write it up clearly. A doctoral dissertation must do something more: it must add new knowledge to your field. The examiners' central question is not 'Did the candidate do good research?' but 'What is new here, and why does it matter?' Everything in this guide follows from that difference.

1.1 Scale, time and independence

The most obvious change is scale. A master's thesis is usually written in a few months, alongside taught courses, and the supervisor often suggests the topic. A doctorate takes several years of full-time work, and the candidate is expected to own the project: to choose the question, to design the study, to solve the problems that

arise, and to decide when the work is finished. Supervisors guide and challenge, but they do not manage the project day by day. Many new doctoral students find this freedom disorienting at first, and the first skill to learn is self-management: setting your own deadlines and keeping them when nobody is checking.

1.2 What examiners expect at doctoral level

Doctoral examiners look for four things. First, originality: a finding, an explanation, a method or an application that did not exist before. Second, rigour: methods that are sound, evidence that is honestly reported, and analysis that can be followed and checked. Third, coherence: a single argument that runs through the whole thesis, with every chapter serving it. Fourth, mastery of the field: a candidate who knows the literature well enough to discuss it critically and to answer hard questions about it. A thesis can be long and well written and still fail if it lacks originality, and a modest thesis can pass with distinction if its contribution is clear and well defended.

Worked Example: A master's answer and a doctoral answer

Master's answer: 'This study measured reading fluency in 40 Grade 6 students before and after a six-week programme, and found an improvement.' That is competent, useful work. Doctoral answer: 'This study tested a new explanation for why fluency gains fade after intervention, using three groups over one school year, and found that gains persist only when practice continues — a result that changes how the programme should be scheduled.' The second version does not just report a result; it tests an explanation, extends the time frame, and changes practice. That is the step up the doctorate demands.

Feature	Master's thesis	PhD dissertation
Main goal	Show competence in research	Make an original contribution
Typical length	Shorter; one study	Much longer; often several studies
Topic	Often suggested by supervisor	Chosen and owned by the candidate
Literature review	Shows understanding	Judges the field, finds the gap
Examination	Often no oral defence	Oral defence (viva) by experts
Time	Months	Several years

[ ] I can state in one sentence what will be new about my doctorate.

[ ] I understand my university's doctoral regulations and word limits.

[ ] I have discussed the scale of the project honestly with my supervisor.

[ ] I have a plan for managing several years of independent work.

Chapter 2: The Long Journey: Stages and a Realistic Timeline

A doctorate is a marathon, and the candidates who finish are rarely the fastest starters. They are the ones who planned the distance, kept a steady pace, and did not burn out in the first year. The first task is therefore not reading or writing, but planning: breaking three or four years into stages, each with a clear product — a proposal, a literature review, a pilot study, data collection, analysis, drafts, a complete thesis, a defence. A stage without a product is a stage that drifts, and drift is the doctorate's greatest enemy.

Most universities divide the doctorate into the same broad stages, though the names differ. The first stage is the proposal and the confirmation of candidature, in which the question and the plan are approved. The second stage is the literature review and the research design, including any pilot work. The third is data collection. The fourth is analysis and writing. The final stage is revision, submission and defence. Each stage takes longer than a new student expects, and the plan should say so openly: a timeline that assumes nothing will go wrong is not a plan, it is a wish.

2.1 A realistic year-by-year plan

A useful rule is to plan backwards from the submission date. Decide when you must submit, then work backwards: the final two or three months are for revision, proofreading and formatting, so the complete draft must exist before them. The defence and corrections need their own time after submission. Writing itself takes far longer than most candidates expect — a full draft of a long thesis commonly takes a year of steady writing, not a few months of intense effort. The plan should therefore show writing starting early, in the second year, with chapters drafted as the work progresses rather than all at once at the end.

2.2 Milestones and the annual review

Turn the plan into dated milestones and write them down: proposal approved, literature review drafted, pilot study completed, data collection finished, first full draft, submission. Share the milestones with your supervisor and review them together at least once a term. Most universities also hold a formal annual review or progress examination, in which you present your work to a small panel. Treat that review as a rehearsal for the defence: it is the best early warning system you will get, and a panel that raises concerns is helping you, not attacking you.

Worked Example: A realistic timeline for a three-year doctorate

Year 1: proposal approved, literature review drafted, methods chosen, pilot study run and reported. Year 2: main data collection, analysis begun, methodology and literature

chapters drafted, one conference paper presented. Year 3: analysis completed, results and discussion drafted, full draft to supervisor, revision, submission, defence. Note what this plan does not contain: no writing left entirely to the final six months, and no stage without a visible product. If your university allows four years, stretch the middle stages rather than the final one.

Stage	Main product	Common delay
Proposal and confirmation	Approved proposal	Question too broad; needs narrowing
Literature and design	Review draft, instruments	Reading without writing
Data collection	Complete dataset	Access, permissions, recruitment
Analysis and writing	Full draft chapter by chapter	Writing left to the end
Revision and submission	Submitted thesis	Formatting and referencing fixes
Defence and corrections	Corrected final thesis	Examiner availability

[ ] I have a written timeline with dated milestones for every stage.

[ ] Writing is scheduled from the second year, not only at the end.

[ ] I have allowed time for delays, revision and formatting.

[ ] My supervisor has seen the timeline and agrees it is realistic.

[ ] I review progress against the milestones at least once a term.

Chapter 3: From Proposal to Full Dissertation

The research proposal is the first formal document of the doctorate, and it is also the most important, because it fixes the question, the method and the scope that the whole thesis will follow. A good proposal is not a promise to do everything; it is a clear, limited plan that a reader can judge. It says what the problem is, what question will be answered, what is already known, how the study will be done, and what the expected contribution is. Supervisors and panels judge a proposal on whether the question is answerable in the time available — not on whether it is ambitious.

The most common fault in proposals is a question that is too broad. 'How can

education be improved?' cannot be answered by one study. 'Does weekly formative feedback improve the test scores of Grade 9 mathematics students in public schools over one term?' can be answered, and the proposal can show exactly how. Narrowing the question is not lowering your ambition; it is what makes the ambition achievable. A doctoral question should be big enough to matter and small enough to answer.

3.1 What a strong proposal contains

A strong proposal usually contains the same elements in every university: a background that shows the problem matters; a statement of the problem and the research questions; a short review showing what is known and where the gap is; the aims and objectives; the methodology, including design, participants, instruments and analysis; the ethical issues and how they will be handled; a timeline; and the expected contribution. Each element should be short. The proposal is a plan, not the thesis itself, and a proposal that tries to answer the question before the research begins is a proposal that has misunderstood its job.

3.2 From proposal to thesis: what changes and what stays

Once the proposal is approved, the thesis grows out of it, but it does not simply repeat it. The introduction chapter expands the background. The literature review becomes a full chapter. The methodology chapter develops the short methods section into a complete, justified account. The results and discussion are entirely new. Two things from the proposal should survive unchanged: the research question and the claim to originality. If the question changes during the doctorate — and it often does, as the literature and the pilot study teach you things — record the change, explain why, and get your supervisor's agreement in writing. A question that drifts silently is a thesis that loses its shape.

Worked Example: Narrowing a proposal question

Too broad: 'What affects student performance in science?' It names no population, no factor and no outcome. Workable: 'Does structured laboratory practice improve the practical examination scores of Grade 10 science students in two public schools over one term?' This version names the intervention, the outcome, the population, the setting and the time frame. A panel can now judge whether the study is feasible — and so can the candidate.

- [ ] My research question names the intervention, the outcome and the population.
- [ ] The proposal states what is already known and where the gap is.
- [ ] The method is described in enough detail to judge its feasibility.
- [ ] Ethical issues are named and a plan for approval is included.
- [ ] The timeline fits the time available, with room for delays.

Chapter 4: The Originality Requirement

Originality is the word that frightens doctoral students most, because it sounds as if the thesis must discover something nobody has ever thought of. In practice, originality is more ordinary and more achievable than that. It means that the thesis adds something new to what is known: a new finding, a new explanation, a new method, a new application of an existing idea to a new setting, or a new synthesis of existing ideas. Most doctoral theses are original in one of these modest ways, and examiners are looking for a clear, honest claim of that kind — not for a revolution.

The claim must be stated explicitly, in the introduction and again in the conclusion, in language the examiner cannot miss. A contribution that is never stated is a contribution the examiner may not notice. The claim should also be proportionate: do not claim to have transformed a field when your study tested one intervention in two schools. Examiners respect a modest claim that the evidence supports, and they distrust a grand claim that it does not.

4.1 Five kinds of originality

The first kind is a new finding: data that did not exist before, answering a question that had not been answered. The second is a new explanation: existing findings understood in a new way, for example by testing a mechanism that earlier studies only guessed at. The third is a new method: a better instrument, a better design, or a technique applied to a new problem. The fourth is a new context: a well-tested idea examined in a population or setting where it had not been tested, where the result is not obvious in advance. The fifth is a new synthesis: bringing together separate lines of research to produce an understanding that none of them gave alone. Most theses combine two of these, and the introduction should name them plainly.

Worked Example: Stating the contribution clearly

Weak: 'This study will contribute to the literature on feedback.' Every study could say that. Strong: 'This study is the first to test whether structured peer feedback improves writing accuracy in intermediate learners in public schools over a full school year, and it explains the result by testing whether explaining errors to a peer is the mechanism. It therefore extends earlier short-term findings and gives schools a practical basis for scheduling peer feedback.' The strong version names the finding, the explanation, the context and the use. An examiner can now judge it.

- [ ] I can state my contribution in one or two sentences.
- [ ] The contribution is one of the five kinds named in this chapter.
- [ ] The claim is proportionate to the evidence the study will produce.
- [ ] The claim is stated in the proposal, the introduction and the conclusion.
- [ ] A sceptical colleague has heard the claim and found it convincing.

Chapter 5: Literature Review at Doctoral Depth

At master's level, a literature review shows that you have read the field. At doctoral level, it must show that you can judge it. The examiner expects a review that maps the field, identifies its disagreements and weaknesses, and ends in a gap that only your study can fill. A doctoral review is longer, deeper and more critical than a master's review, and it is usually written over many months, revised as the research progresses, and finished only when the analysis is done — because the findings often change which literature matters most.

The review should be organised by theme or by argument, never by author. Group the literature into three to five themes that follow from your question, discuss the studies in each theme together, and end each theme with your own judgement: what is established, what is contested, and what is missing. The final section of the review states the gap explicitly and presents your conceptual framework — the set of relationships your study will test. That section is the bridge to the methodology chapter, and the examiner will judge the whole thesis partly on whether the bridge holds.

5.1 Reading widely, then reading deeply

Doctoral reading happens in two passes. The first pass is wide: survey the field, find the key journals, the major debates and the most-cited studies, and map the territory. The second pass is deep: read the most important studies carefully, examine their methods, and judge the strength of their evidence. Keep a reading log from the start — a short note for each source, recording what it found, how it found it, and what you think of it. A log written as you read is worth far more than a pile of papers revisited a year later, when you no longer remember why each one mattered.

5.2 Critical evaluation, not summary

Every paragraph of a doctoral review should do three things: summarise what a study did, synthesise it with the other studies in the theme, and evaluate it. Evaluation asks: was the sample large enough, the design sound, the measure valid, the context similar to yours? A study with twelve participants and no control group can suggest an idea, but it cannot settle a question, and the review should say so. The marks at doctoral level are earned at this level. A single sentence of evaluation is worth more than a page of uncritical summary.

Worked Example: From listing to critical synthesis

Listing: 'Ali (2021) studied feedback in Lahore. Khan (2022) studied feedback in Karachi. Raza (2023) studied feedback in Islamabad.' Synthesis: 'Studies in three cities agree that students value feedback but rarely act on it. However, all three relied on self-report questionnaires, and none measured whether accuracy actually improved — the gap this study addresses by combining a controlled comparison with an analysis of students' revised work.' The second version turns three facts into one argument, names the weakness, and states the gap.

[ ] Sources are grouped by theme, with a synthesis at the end of each theme.

[ ] Key studies are evaluated for method and sample, not only summarised.

[ ] The gap is stated explicitly and leads directly to the research questions.

[ ] A conceptual framework is presented at the end of the review.

[ ] A reading log is kept for every source, written as it is read.

[ ] The review has been updated with recent literature before submission.

Chapter 6: Methodology and Research Design

The methodology chapter is the chapter examiners scrutinise most closely, because a weak method undermines everything that follows. It must allow a competent reader to understand exactly what you did, why you did it, and whether they could repeat it. At doctoral level, it is not enough to name your method; you must defend it. Why this design and not another? Why this sample? Why this instrument? Why this analysis? A choice without a reason looks arbitrary. A choice with a reason looks like a decision, and examiners reward decisions they can follow, even when they would have chosen differently.

Write the methodology chapter in the past tense, in enough detail for replication, and in the order the work happened. Put the full instruments in an appendix and refer the reader to them. Most importantly, be honest about the limits of your approach. Every method has weaknesses, and naming them shows that you understand your own evidence. A methodology chapter that claims perfection is a chapter the examiner will not trust.

6.1 Choosing and justifying the design

Name the design in one sentence, then defend it in a paragraph. An experiment tests cause and effect; a survey describes attitudes or practices across a population; a case study explores a phenomenon in depth in its real context; a mixed-methods design combines numbers and words to answer different parts of the question. State the alternatives you considered and why this design was the best fit for your question, your time and your access. In a doctorate, a mixed-methods design is common, because doctoral questions often have both a 'how much' part and a 'why' part — but combining methods must be planned, not improvised: the two parts should answer different sub-questions, and the chapter should explain how their findings will be brought together.

6.2 Participants, sampling and setting

Describe who took part, how many, how they were selected, and where the study happened. Give the numbers: the population, the sample size, the response rate, and the characteristics that matter, such as age, grade or experience. Explain the sampling method — random, purposive, convenience — and be honest about its limits. A convenience sample is not a disgrace, but it must be named as one, and its effect on generalisation must be discussed in the conclusion. In doctoral work, the sample must be large enough or deep enough to support the claim you intend to

make; a claim about a whole population cannot rest on twelve participants.

6.3 Instruments, pilot testing and analysis

Describe each instrument: the questionnaire, the test, the interview schedule, the observation checklist. Say where it came from — adapted from an earlier study or designed by you — and report its quality. Pilot testing is essential at doctoral level: run the instruments with a small group first, find the items that are misunderstood, and revise them before the main study. Report the pilot honestly, including what you changed and why. Then name the analysis before you present the results: the statistical tests and the software for quantitative data, or the approach to coding and themes for qualitative data, and how you checked the trustworthiness of the analysis, for example by having a second coder check a sample of transcripts.

6.4 Ethics at doctoral level

Every doctorate involving people must address ethics thoroughly: informed consent, voluntary participation, the right to withdraw, confidentiality, and secure storage of data. State the approval you obtained from your university's ethics committee and the relevant authorities, and give the reference number if one was issued. Describe in practical terms what participants were told and how their identities were protected. Doctoral fieldwork often involves vulnerable groups or sensitive topics, and examiners treat a thin ethics section as a serious fault. If your study changed direction after approval, say so, and say whether fresh approval was sought.

Worked Example: Justifying a choice, not just naming it

Weak: 'A questionnaire was used.' The reader learns nothing about why. Strong: 'A questionnaire was used because the study needed comparable data from 300 students in six schools within eight weeks, which interviews could not provide in the time available. The items were adapted from a validated instrument, piloted with 30 students, and revised after the pilot showed that three items were misunderstood. A second coder checked a sample of the open responses, with agreement above the level the study had set in advance.' The strong version gives the reason, the constraint, and the quality checks — the three things a doctoral examiner looks for.

- [ ] Design, sample, instruments, procedure and analysis are all described.
- [ ] Every major choice is justified, with alternatives considered.
- [ ] Instruments are piloted and revised; reliability and validity are reported.
- [ ] Ethical approval and consent procedures are stated, with reference numbers.
- [ ] A reader could repeat the study from this chapter alone.

Chapter 7: Fieldwork and Data Collection

Fieldwork is where the doctorate meets the real world, and the real world rarely cooperates with a plan. Schools close, participants withdraw, equipment fails, permissions arrive late. The candidates who survive fieldwork are not the lucky ones; they are the ones who planned for trouble. Before you begin, list everything that could go wrong, and write down what you will do in each case: a reserve school if one withdraws, a second round of recruitment if the response is low, a backup for every piece of equipment. A contingency plan written in advance is worth far more than a clever improvisation under pressure.

Keep a fieldwork diary from the first day. Record what happened each day, what went wrong, what you decided, and why. The diary serves two purposes: it keeps the project organised, and it becomes evidence in the methodology chapter that the study was conducted carefully. Examiners sometimes ask how a particular decision was made during fieldwork, and a candidate who can answer from a diary is a candidate who looks in control of the project.

7.1 Access, permissions and recruitment

Access is the most underestimated part of fieldwork. Institutions need time to consider a request, and a polite refusal at the top can close a door that a conversation at a lower level would have opened. Start the process early — months before you need to begin — and approach the right person with a short, clear request: what you want to do, how long it will take, what it will cost the institution, and what it will receive in return. Get permissions in writing, keep copies, and confirm the arrangements a week before you start. For recruitment, explain the study in plain language, stress that participation is voluntary, and never pressure anyone who declines.

7.2 Collecting data carefully

Collect data the same way every time. Use the same instructions, the same order, the same conditions, so that differences in the results reflect differences in the participants, not differences in how you collected the data. Check the data as you collect it: count the questionnaires at the end of each day, listen to a sample of each recording, and back up everything in two places the same evening. Lost data cannot be recovered, and a candidate who discovers a gap months later has no way to fill it. A short daily check — 'Did I collect what I planned to collect today, and is it safely stored?' — prevents most disasters.

Worked Example: A fieldwork problem, handled well

Fictional case: a doctoral candidate planned to collect data in four schools, but one school withdrew a week before the start, citing examination pressure. The candidate recorded the withdrawal, contacted a reserve school that had already given provisional agreement, and completed data collection on schedule with the same instruments and the same number of participants. The thesis reported the change in one paragraph, noted

that the reserve school was similar in size and setting, and discussed the effect on the sample in the limitations section. The examiners praised the handling of the problem rather than penalising it.

[ ] Permissions are obtained in writing, well before fieldwork begins.

[ ] A reserve site or a second recruitment round is planned in advance.

[ ] Data are collected the same way every time and backed up daily.

[ ] A fieldwork diary records each day, each problem and each decision.

[ ] Any change to the plan is agreed with the supervisor and reported honestly.

Chapter 8: Analysis and Results

Analysis is where data become findings, and the results chapter is where the findings are presented. The two must be kept separate in your mind, even though they are often written together. Analysis is the work you do on the data: the tests, the coding, the counting, the checking. Results are what you show the reader: the numbers, the tables, the themes, the quotations. The reader needs to trust both, so the thesis must show enough of the analysis for the reader to follow it, and enough of the results for the reader to judge them.

The results chapter presents what you found — nothing more. Do not interpret the findings here, do not compare them with the literature, and do not explain why they happened. That is the discussion chapter's job. The most common fault in doctoral results chapters is mixing results with interpretation, so that the reader cannot tell where the data end and the author's opinion begins. Keep the two apart, and the discussion will be far easier to write.

8.1 Quantitative analysis and presentation

For quantitative data, state the analysis plan before presenting the results: which tests were used, why they were appropriate, and what significance level was adopted. Present the findings in the order of the research questions, and use tables for precise numbers and figures for patterns. Every table and figure needs a number, a clear title, and a note explaining it, and the text should point out the one or two findings that matter most rather than repeating every number. Report unexpected and non-significant results as honestly as the significant ones; hiding them is a serious breach of research integrity, and examiners will ask about them.

Group	Pre-test mean	Post-test mean	Gain
Peer feedback (n = 100)	58.4	71.2	+12.8
Teacher feedback (n = 100)	57.9	66.3	+8.4

Combined feedback (n = 100)	58.0	73.5	+15.5
Control (n = 100)	58.1	59.6	+1.5

The table above is a fictional example of a results table from a doctoral study with four groups. Note what it does: the groups are named, the sample sizes are shown, and the key column — the gain — is visible at a glance. In the text, the writer would draw attention to the comparison that matters: the combined-feedback group gained most, and the control group barely changed. The table carries the numbers; the text carries the message.

8.2 Qualitative analysis and presentation

For qualitative data, present the findings as themes, each illustrated with short quotations from participants. Describe the analysis steps — transcription, coding, searching for themes, checking them against the data — so that the reader can see how the themes were reached. Choose quotations that show the theme clearly, give each a participant code rather than a name, and keep them short. The theme, not the quotation, is the finding; the quotation is the evidence for it. Aim for a small number of well-developed themes rather than a long list of thin ones, and include at least one theme that surprised you — it shows that the analysis was genuinely open to the data.

[ ] The analysis plan is stated before the results are presented.

[ ] Results are organised by research question, in the same order as the introduction.

[ ] Every table and figure is numbered, titled and referred to in the text.

[ ] Non-significant and unexpected results are reported, not hidden.

[ ] Themes are checked against the full dataset, with a second coder where possible.

[ ] No interpretation or literature comparison appears in this chapter.

Chapter 9: Discussion and Contribution

The discussion is where the doctorate earns its degree. Results describe what happened; the discussion argues what it means. A strong discussion does five things: it answers each research question directly, it compares the findings with the earlier literature, it explains unexpected results, it states the contribution to knowledge, and it acknowledges the study's limitations honestly. Students often write the discussion as a second results chapter, repeating the numbers. Resist that. The reader has already seen the numbers; now they need your judgement.

Begin the discussion by answering each research question in turn, in one paragraph per question, referring back to the key evidence. Do not make the reader wait until the end of the chapter to learn the answer. A useful opening sentence is: 'The first research question asked whether combined feedback improves writing accuracy over a full school year. The evidence suggests that it does, and by a larger margin than

either form of feedback alone.' Everything after that sentence supports, qualifies or explains it.

9.1 Comparing findings with the literature

For each main finding, return to the literature review and say whether your results agree or disagree with earlier studies, and why. Agreement strengthens the earlier finding and extends it to a new context. Disagreement is often more interesting: it may be explained by a different population, a different instrument, a longer time period, or a genuine change in the phenomenon. Do not ignore studies that contradict you. Examiners will have read them, and a thesis that confronts contrary evidence is far stronger than one that pretends it does not exist. Where your findings disagree with a well-known study, explain the disagreement carefully — it may be the most original part of your thesis.

9.2 Claiming the contribution

The discussion is where the contribution claimed in the introduction must be delivered. State it again, now with the evidence behind it: what is now known that was not known before, and for whom it matters. Distinguish the theoretical contribution — a new explanation, a refined concept, a tested mechanism — from the practical contribution — what teachers, managers or policymakers should do differently. Keep the claim proportionate to the evidence, and name its limits in the same breath. A contribution stated clearly and modestly is a contribution the examiner can accept.

9.3 Limitations — stated, not apologised for

State the limitations plainly: the sample came from one region, the study ran for one school year, the test measured only one kind of accuracy. Then say what each limitation means for the findings: which conclusions it weakens and which it leaves untouched. A limitation is not an apology. Every study has limits, and naming them shows that you understand the reach of your own evidence. What damages a thesis is not having limitations, but pretending not to have them — and what strengthens it is showing that the main conclusions survive the limitations.

Worked Example: A discussion paragraph that does the work

'The combined-feedback group improved by 15.5 points, compared with 12.8 for peer feedback alone and 8.4 for teacher feedback. This supports the claim that structured peer interaction helps learners notice errors, and it extends that claim in two ways: it shows the effect over a full school year, and it shows that combining peer and teacher feedback adds a further gain. The most likely mechanism is that peer discussion forced learners to explain errors in their own words, while teacher feedback then corrected the explanations that were wrong — a combination no earlier study had tested.' In a few sentences this paragraph answers the question, compares with earlier work, claims the contribution, and offers a mechanism. That is the standard to aim for.

[ ] Each research question is answered directly, early in the chapter.

[ ] Every main finding is compared with the earlier literature.

[ ] Unexpected results are explained, not ignored.

[ ] The contribution is stated again, with the evidence behind it.

[ ] Limitations are stated with their consequences for the findings.

[ ] No new results appear in this chapter.

Chapter 10: Writing the Thesis — a Sustainable Drafting Routine

The most common reason doctoral students fail to finish is not lack of ability; it is that they stop writing. The thesis is too long to write in a burst of inspiration, and the students who finish are the ones who write a little every day, for months, whether they feel inspired or not. The goal is not to write well every day; it is to write every day, and to revise later. A bad draft can be revised. A blank page cannot.

Build the routine around small, regular sessions rather than heroic weekends. Two focused hours a day, five days a week, will produce a full draft in a year. Protect that time: treat it as a meeting with yourself that cannot be cancelled for anything less than a genuine emergency. Write in the morning if you can, when your mind is fresh, and stop at a point where you know what the next sentence will be — it makes starting again tomorrow far easier. Keep a simple log of words written each day; on a bad week, the log will show you that you are still moving, and that is often enough to keep going.

10.1 Drafting chapter by chapter

Draft the chapters in the order the work is done, not the order they appear in the thesis. The methodology chapter can be drafted while the study is running, because you know what you are doing. The results chapter can be drafted as the analysis is finished, while the numbers are fresh. The literature review is drafted early and revised late. The introduction and the conclusion are written last, because only then do you know exactly what the thesis claims. Send each chapter to your supervisor as you finish it, rather than waiting until the whole thesis is drafted: early feedback on one chapter prevents the same mistake in five others.

10.3 Revising in passes

Revise in passes, not all at once. The first pass is for structure: does each chapter do its job, and does the argument flow? The second pass is for sense: does each paragraph make one point, and does each sentence follow from the one before? The third pass is for language: spelling, grammar, punctuation, consistency of terms and numbers. Read the thesis aloud, or have it read aloud to you — the ear catches errors the eye misses. Finally, ask a careful reader outside your field to read two chapters; if they cannot follow the argument, the examiner may not be able to either.

Worked Example: A weekly writing plan that survives real life

Monday to Friday, 9:00 to 11:00: writing only — no email, no reading, no admin. Monday

afternoon: reading and notes for the chapter in progress. Wednesday afternoon: one hour with the supervisor's comments from the previous draft. Friday afternoon: plan next week's writing target in one sentence, and record this week's word count. The plan works because it is small, regular and honest: ten hours of writing a week, every week, is enough to finish a doctorate — and a plan that demands forty hours a week will collapse in the first month.

[ ] I write at regular times each week, protected from other work.

[ ] Each chapter is drafted as the work is done, not all at once at the end.

[ ] Drafts go to my supervisor chapter by chapter.

[ ] I revise in passes: structure, then sense, then language.

[ ] I have a plan for getting unstuck that does not depend on inspiration.

Chapter 11: Working with Your Supervisor and Committee

The supervisor is the most important relationship in a doctorate, and it is a working relationship that needs managing like any other. Supervisors differ widely: some meet weekly and read every draft, others meet monthly and expect the candidate to work independently. Neither style is wrong, but the candidate must know which one they have, and must agree early on how the relationship will work: how often you will meet, what you will bring to each meeting, how quickly drafts will be returned, and how feedback will be given. An agreement made in the first month prevents most of the misunderstandings that damage doctorates in the third year.

The candidate's job is to make supervision easy: arrive with a written agenda, send material in advance, and bring a specific question rather than a general worry. 'I am stuck' is hard to help with; 'I cannot decide between these two designs, and here are the arguments for each' is easy to help with. Keep a short record of each meeting — what was agreed, and who will do what by when — and send it to your supervisor afterwards. It protects both of you, and it creates a record of decisions that is useful when the thesis is examined.

11.1 Using feedback well

Supervisors give feedback to improve the thesis, not to judge the candidate, but it rarely feels that way when a draft comes back covered in comments. Read the feedback once, put it aside for a day, and then work through it comment by comment. Sort the comments into three groups: changes you agree with and will make; changes you disagree with, where you will explain your reason; and questions you need to discuss. Never ignore a comment silently — if you disagree, say so and give your reason. Supervisors respect a candidate who defends a choice with an argument far more than one who accepts every suggestion without thinking.

11.2 The committee, the second supervisor and the annual review

Most doctorates involve more people than the main supervisor: a second supervisor, a committee, or a progress panel. Each of them sees the work from a different angle,

and their questions are a free rehearsal for the defence. Treat the annual review seriously: prepare a short presentation, bring the work you have done, and listen to the concerns raised. A panel that asks hard questions is doing its job. If the panel's advice conflicts with your supervisor's, say so openly and ask them to agree a way forward together — do not try to satisfy both by writing two different theses.

Worked Example: A supervision meeting that works

The candidate sends a one-page agenda two days before the meeting: the question to decide, the draft attached, and the three comments from the last meeting that have been addressed. The meeting lasts 45 minutes: ten minutes on progress, twenty on the question, ten on the draft, five on the next steps. Afterwards the candidate sends a short note: 'We agreed I will revise Chapter 5 by the end of the month, and you will return it within two weeks.' Both sides know what is expected, and the next meeting starts from that note rather than from scratch.

[ ] Meeting frequency, draft turnaround and feedback style are agreed in writing.

[ ] I send an agenda and material in advance of every meeting.

[ ] I keep a written record of each meeting and the decisions made.

[ ] Feedback is worked through comment by comment, never ignored silently.

[ ] I know the university's formal route if supervision breaks down.

Chapter 12: The Defence (Viva) — Preparation and the Day Itself

The defence — called the viva voce, or viva, in many universities — is an oral examination of the thesis, usually lasting one to three hours. Its purpose is not to catch you out. The examiners want to establish that the work is yours, that you understand it, and that you can defend its claims. Most candidates who know their thesis well pass, often with minor corrections. Preparation, not brilliance, is what makes the difference — and the preparation begins months before the day, not the week before it.

The first preparation is to know the thesis. Read it again from start to finish, as an examiner would, and mark the weak points: the claims that need more evidence, the methods that could be challenged, the results that could be read differently. Write down the questions an examiner might ask about each weak point, and prepare an answer. If you cannot answer a question about your own thesis, the examiner will find it — so find it first.

12.1 What examiners ask

Examiners ask the same kinds of questions in almost every defence. Why did you choose this topic? What is original about your study? Why did you choose this method rather than another? How do you explain this unexpected result? What are the limitations? What would you do differently if you started again? What should future research investigate? Prepare a two-minute answer to each of these before the day,

and practise saying them aloud. If you cannot answer 'What is original about your study?' in one sentence, return to Chapter 4 and find the answer before the defence. Also prepare for the question that has no good answer — the genuine weakness in the study — and practise saying so honestly: 'That is a limitation, and it means the finding should be read as suggestive rather than conclusive.' Examiners respect honesty far more than evasion.

12.2 The presentation and the mock viva

Many defences begin with a short presentation of ten to twenty minutes. Structure it like the thesis in miniature: the problem, the question, the method, the main findings, the contribution. Use few slides, large text, and one clear visual per finding. Do not read the slides aloud; the examiners have the thesis. Rehearse the presentation with a timer, and rehearse it standing up, because that is how you will deliver it. Then arrange a mock viva: ask your supervisor or a colleague to examine you for an hour, using hard questions, and to give you honest feedback afterwards. A mock viva is uncomfortable, and it is the single best preparation there is.

12.3 On the day

Listen to each question in full before answering, and if you do not understand a question, ask the examiner to rephrase it. It is acceptable to say 'I need a moment to think' or 'I do not know, but the evidence suggests...'. Never invent an answer, and never argue with an examiner about a fact you are unsure of. If you disagree with a criticism, say so calmly and give your reason; examiners expect a discussion, not a surrender. When the examiners leave the room to decide, wait patiently — the discussion is usually about the corrections, not about whether you pass.

Possible outcome	What it usually means	What happens next
Pass with no corrections	Thesis accepted as it stands	Final submission only
Pass with minor corrections	Small fixes within weeks	Correct, supervisor checks, submit
Pass with major corrections	Substantial revision needed	Revise over months, re-examined
Revise and resubmit	Thesis needs major reworking	Long revision, second defence possible
Fail	Very rare; thesis not acceptable	University appeal and advice routes

[ ] I have re-read the whole thesis and marked its weak points.

[ ] I can answer the standard defence questions in two minutes each.

[ ] I have rehearsed the presentation with a timer.

[ ] I have done a mock viva with hard questions.

[ ] I bring the thesis, a notebook and a list of known corrections on the day.

Chapter 13: Corrections and Final Submission

For most candidates, the defence does not end the doctorate; it begins the corrections. The examiners will give you a list of changes to make, ranging from a few typing errors to substantial revisions of a chapter. The first task is to read the list carefully and to sort it: corrections you understand and agree with; corrections you do not understand, which you should ask your supervisor about; and corrections you disagree with, where you should discuss the matter with your supervisor before deciding. Do not start correcting until the list is clear, and do not rush — the deadline for corrections is usually generous, and a careful correction is worth more than a fast one.

Work through the list systematically, keeping a record of each change: the examiner's point, the page where you made the change, and what you changed. This record — sometimes called a corrections log — is often required by the university, and it is also useful evidence that the work was done thoroughly. When the corrections are finished, your supervisor will normally check them before the final submission. Allow time for that check, and for the formatting and printing requirements that follow it.

13.1 The final submission

Final submission has its own requirements, and they vary by university: the number of copies, the binding, the electronic format, the declaration pages, and the deposit of the thesis in the university library or repository. Check the requirements early — ideally before the defence — so that the final weeks are not spent discovering that the margins are wrong or a page is missing. Submit the final version only when the corrections have been checked and the formatting has been verified against the regulations. Keep a backup copy of the final file in a safe place, separate from your working copy.

[ ] The examiners' corrections list is sorted and fully understood.

[ ] A corrections log records every change and where it was made.

[ ] The supervisor has checked the corrections before final submission.

[ ] Formatting, binding and electronic deposit meet the regulations.

[ ] A backup copy of the final thesis is kept separately.

Chapter 14: Common Pitfalls and a Final Checklist

The pitfalls below appear in doctorate after doctorate, in every subject and every university. They are not failures of intelligence; they are failures of planning, and every one of them is avoidable. Read this chapter a year before submission, when there is still time to fix what it finds — and again a month before submission, as a final check.

14.1 The ten most common pitfalls

- A research question that stays too broad, so the thesis never finishes answering it.
- Reading without writing, so that three years of notes never become a draft.
- Leaving all the writing to the final year, when there is no time to revise properly.
- A literature review that summarises the field instead of judging it and finding the gap.
- A methodology chapter that names choices without justifying them.
- Results mixed with interpretation, so the reader cannot tell evidence from opinion.
- A contribution that is never stated clearly, so the examiners have to guess it.
- Avoiding the supervisor for months, then arriving with a crisis.
- Claiming more than the evidence supports — 'proves' where the data only 'suggest'.
- Leaving formatting, referencing and proofreading to the last week.

14.2 The final checklist

Work through this checklist with the printed thesis in front of you. Tick each item only when you have checked it on the page, not from memory.

[ ] The research question is stated in the introduction and answered in the conclusion.

[ ] The original contribution is stated clearly in the introduction and the conclusion.

[ ] Every chapter has a clear purpose, stated in its opening paragraph.

[ ] The literature review ends in a stated gap that the study fills.

[ ] The methodology chapter would allow a reader to repeat the study.

[ ] Every table and figure is numbered, titled and referred to in the text.

[ ] The discussion answers each question and claims the contribution with evidence.

[ ] Limitations are stated honestly, with their consequences for the findings.

[ ] Every citation appears in the reference list, and every reference is cited.

[ ] Page numbers, headings and the table of contents match.

[ ] The thesis has been proofread aloud, and a second reader has checked it.

[ ] The file is saved in the required format, with a backup copy kept separately.

Chapter 15: Conclusion

A doctorate is a long undertaking, and the candidates who finish it are rarely the most brilliant in their cohort. They are the most organised and the most persistent: they plan the whole project before they begin, they write a little every day, they show drafts to their supervisor early and often, they treat feedback as information rather than criticism, and they keep going when the work is difficult. The structure in this guide is a tool for that persistence. It tells you what each stage must produce, so that you never have to face a blank page — or a blank year — wondering what to do next.

If you take one idea from this guide, let it be this: the doctorate is one argument, and every part of it serves that argument. State the question clearly. Show why it is still open. Gather the evidence fairly. Present it honestly. Interpret it carefully. State what is now known that was not known before, and defend that claim in the viva. Do that, in plain and precise language, and the thesis will stand up to examination — not because it is long, but because it is sound.

Write the first draft badly if you must; a bad draft can be revised, and a blank page cannot. Then revise with the checklists in this guide, proofread with fresh eyes, and defend the work with the confidence of someone who knows exactly what it claims and why. Good luck — and keep writing.

Suggested Reading

The following are well-known general works on doctoral research and academic writing that students commonly consult. Check your university library for the latest editions, and follow your department's guidance on referencing style.

- General research methods textbooks: standard methodology texts used in most universities cover research design, sampling, data collection and analysis for quantitative, qualitative and mixed-methods studies at doctoral level.
- Guides to writing a doctoral thesis: widely used books on the doctorate explain structure, argument, originality and the viva, with examples of good practice across subjects.
- Academic writing guides: general guides to scholarly writing cover clarity, style, argument and revision, with exercises a candidate can use while drafting.
- Style manuals: the official manuals of the major referencing styles (APA, Harvard, Chicago, MLA) are the authoritative source for citation and formatting rules — consult the edition your department requires.
- Your university's doctoral regulations and thesis template: always the first and final authority on structure, word count, formatting, examination and submission requirements.
- Your supervisor's recommended reading list for your subject: the most relevant source of all, because it is chosen for your specific topic and method.